

Clouds

Clouds are made of minute water droplets or ice condensed around tiny specks of dust that are blown in the air. Clouds are mostly white because their water droplets scatter a lot of light. When the cloud is filled with water and close to raining, it looks dark gray because it absorbs a lot of light.

▽ **Cloud types**
Below are types of cloud that are defined by their height and appearance.



1. Cirrostratus

These flat and wispy clouds form at high altitudes from ice crystals.

2. Cirrus

Cirrus are high, wispy clouds, and indicate that stormy weather is likely.

3. Cirrocumulus

These high, fluffy clouds means rain is on its way.

4. Altostratus

Sheets of cloud at medium altitudes suggest gray skies and light rain are likely.

5. Cumulonimbus

The largest cloud of all produces thunderstorms.

6. Altopumulus

These fluffy clouds form at a medium height, and indicate a cold front is coming.

7. Stratocumulus

The wide, fluffy clouds are closer to the ground than altocumulus.

8. Stratus

This cloud is characterized by its horizontal shape.

9. Nimbostratus

This is a stratus cloud with rain.

10. Cumulus

These low-level fluffy clouds form in mild weather.

11. Fog

This stratus cloud can touch the ground.

Weather maps

Meteorologists (people who study weather) show the current atmospheric conditions on weather maps. This is a useful tool for forecasting the weather. The map shows the weather fronts and areas of low and high pressure. An expert meteorologist can predict how the front will move, and so figure out what the weather will be like over a particular region.

▷ Pressure gradients

Isobars (the black lines on the map) link places where the atmospheric pressure is the same. The isobars form rings around centers of low and high pressure. The closer the rings are to each other, the stronger the wind.

high-pressure zones, where it is usually cloudless and sunny, are marked by rings of isobars with the highest pressure near the center

Key



Warm front



Cold front



Occluded front

low-pressure zones, where there are usually strong winds and rainfall, are marked by rings of isobars with the lowest pressure near the center

